MediaTek's Anku Jain believes two-way satellite connectivity will fill the gap in mobile coverage

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Fabless semiconductor manufacturer MediaTek has been dabbling in some pretty interesting avenues in 2023. Not only did they come out with their latest flagship smartphone chipset – the MediaTek Dimensity 9200+ – but they also announced their own iteration of 2-way satellite communication, the brand new Dimensity Auto platform, and more. I recently had the opportunity to converse with Mr Anku Jain, Managing Director of MediaTek India, about the latest developments at MediaTek. He gave us the lowdown on the new announcements and also spoke about the global chip shortage, 5G and 6G R&D, Edge AI, and much more!

Anku Jain
Managing Director of MediaTek India

Q As was shown at MWC 2023 recently, MediaTek has been putting in some serious R&D into developing two-way satellite connectivity in smartphones. So, how do you think this will change the roadmap of smartphone communication or communication, in general, in the future?

A Yeah, I think you're starting with one of the most exciting topics about satellite communication. And as you rightly put it, this was announced at MWC 2023. It was one of the most prominent launches that we showcased at this event. And our chipset, it's called MT6825. It is MediaTek's two-way satellite communications chipset based on 3GPP non-terrestrial network. And what this does is it fills the gap in mobile coverage, provides reliable connectivity in remote locations. Because as I think in India itself, 5G got launched last October. But the coverage will take time. And still, even once the coverage is finished, we will still have some remote locations which will not have coverage. And similarly, in the rest of the world, we always have locations like middle of the ocean or maybe remote mountains and so on. And I think our lifestyle has become such that we always need to be connected. The satellite communications chipset will actually help in that direction. Because it will help users to be always connected. And I think the biggest application would be in smartphones for sure. But also in maybe IoT applications. So it's not only for smartphones. And MediaTek would target both the IoT NTN and also the new radio NTN technology based on 3GPP release 17. So it is really a very, very exciting and a huge step for MediaTek. And we are really looking forward to it. And we'll see how the absorption happens going forward.

Q So as I understand, this is a two-way satellite connection and not just one way. So what are some of the advantages of having two-way connectivity?

A So two-way actually gives major benefits like not only for smartphones. Again, smartphones is given. I mean, we can talk, we can have a video call and so on. But also it has benefits for things like agriculture, logistics, forestry, and automotive. Because as I said earlier, there are two aspects to this. One is the new radio NTN and one is IoT NTN. So for IoT, that will be really something which will help in text transfer, which has low data requirements. But the new radio will be able to support video call, etc. And so this is evolving and I think more and more use cases are coming up. And definitely we will be going forward with some announcements going forward.

Q So in your opinion, has the global chip shortage ended? And what are your thoughts on the post-pandemic recovery of smartphone chip manufacturers like yourself? And also, how do you ensure that chip shortage doesn't dampen user confidence?

A Yeah, I think this has been a hot topic for the last two years. Fortunately, if I go into the past, we have been able to manage this situation quite well. Because we have had a very good relationship with our foundry partners and also we were able to have a good balance of supply and demand with our customers. We were able to go along very well with our customers and ensure that their requirements were met. In fact, in the last three years, our revenue has actually increased a lot in spite of the chip shortage. But going forward, I think this is something which is